

FIRST STEP
Gurmel Singh files his nomination as AAP candidate for the Sangrur bypoll in the presence of CM Bhagwant Mann (right)

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PUNJAB

SANGRUR SHOWDOWN GETS A RADICAL EDGE

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

The untimely deaths within a span of four months of two young public figures from Punjab—actor-activist Deep Sidhu and singer Shubhdeep Singh alias Sidhu Moosewala—and the mammoth outpouring of emotions that followed each are likely to impact the Lok Sabha bypoll in Sangrur due on June 23. The seat was vacated by new chief minister Bhagwant Mann of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) after he won the assembly election from the Dhuri segment in March. In the run-up to the bypoll, the two late entertainers find mention in the speeches of almost every candidate in the fray. With lakhs flocking to the native places of Sidhu and Moosewala for their *antim ardas* (last prayers), no candidate can afford to ignore the emotions triggered by their deaths. The potential impact can be gauged from how comparable gatherings in recent memory—the *antim ardas* of slain Khalistani militant Jugraj 'Toofan' Singh at Cheema Khudi village of Sri Hargobindpur in 1990, and of two Sikhs who fell to police bullets during a 2015 protest in Behbal Kalan against alleged sacrilege at Bargari, Faridkot district—affected politics in the state.

Deep Sidhu, who was accused of instigating Sikh youth to lay siege to Delhi's Red Fort on Republic Day in 2021 during the protests against the farm laws, died in a road accident on February 15, while Moosewala was shot dead on May 29. As Sidhu was said to be a Khalistan sympathiser and Moosewala had occasionally expressed secessionist sentiments, their deaths have tapped into the radical Sikh vein in the state's political minefield. Moreover, the circumstances surrounding Moosewala's murder—his security cover had been halved a day earlier—have led to much public anger against Mann and his government. The Punjab Police has been unable so far to nab the killers or establish a clear motive for the murder.

Hoping, perhaps, to cash in on the sentiments of the rural Sikh population in the Sangrur parliamentary constituency, the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) led by Sukhbir Singh Badal has fielded Kamaldeep Kaur Rajoana, sister of Balwant Singh Rajoana, a jailed Babbar Khalsa International militant who is on death row for the assassination of then chief minister Beant Singh in 1995. This is the first time since the reorganisation of SAD in 1995 that the party has chosen a candidate from a militant's family for a Lok Sabha poll. On May 2, the Supreme Court directed the Centre to decide within two months on the convict's plea to have his death penalty commuted to life imprisonment on the ground that he has already spent almost 26 years in jail. "We are using this bypoll to build up the case for release of all '*bandi* Sikhs' (imprisoned Sikh militants) who have completed their sentence," says Badal, who is going from village to village campaigning for the release of 22 prisoners, including Rajoana's co-accused Jagtar Singh Hawara and 1992 Chandigarh bomb blast convict Devinder Pal Singh Bhullar. The posters behind the campaigners prominently display pictures of Rajoana behind bars.